round of expansion was to take place soon after, but has been getting stuck in what seems like perennial deferment.

The key issue is how to parcel out the meat and gravy. Shinde has spoken about his faction getting an equal number of ministers, which the BJP leaders resent. As the bigger party, the BJP wants a larger share of the pie. Incidentally, after the 2019 election, it was Uddhav's insistence that the Shiv Sena get an equal share in power, including the CM's post, that was the tipping point in the party's ties with the BJP. Sources admit Shinde may have a tough task keeping his flock together if he cannot place them in positions of power. Despite laying claim to being the "real" Shiv Sena, Shinde's group is more of a loose federation of leaders than a political party. Already, legislators like Sanjay Shirsat, a three-term MLA from Aurangabad, and independent MLA Omprakash (Bacchu) Kadu, who was a minister in the MVA government, have made their displeasure evident.

In what has churned the waters further, Shinde and four ministers—Abdul Sattar (agriculture), Shambhuraj Desai (state excise), Uday Samant (industries) and Sanjay Rathod (Food and Drugs Administration or FDA)—have been charged by the Opposition with irregularities in allotment of government lands, undue favours to corporate and such like. Desai and Sattar are seen as among Shinde's closest aides in the cabinet and were among the first batch of Sena MLAs who joined his midnight coup. The spiciest bit: there's speculation if some ammunition against Shinde's men was leaked to the Opposition by the BJP. Says a Congress leader: "The fact that allegations were levelled only against Shinde's ministers and not against those from the BJP says a lot." Uddhav, too, made it explicit on Thursday, saying: "The ministers from their (Shinde) camp must think—how and why are these cases coming out? They must investigate this."

Adding grist to the mill, state BJP chief Chandrashekhar Bavankule says he would like to see Fadnavis back as CM. (The BJP has 112 MLAs; the BBS, even with allied independents and smaller parties, only touches 50.) There are more straws in the wind. BJP leader Chitra Wagh took open umbrage at the induction of Rathod, who had quit as the MVA forest minister in February 2021 after the suicide of a 22-year-old TikTok star. In September, Sattar was reportedly reprimanded by Fadnavis

THE CHARGES

EKNATH SHINDE
Chief Minister



Charged with ordering the Nagpur Improvement Trust (NIT) to allocate 4.5 acres land meant for the urban poor, worth Rs 83 crore, for the "throw-away" price of just Rs 2 crore to 16 persons in Nagpur in 2021, while he was the MVA's urban development minister

ABDUL SATTAR
Agriculture Minister



Charged with allocating 37 acres of gairan (pasture) land in Washim to a private party despite SC and state government orders against such allotments

UDAY SAMANT
Industries Minister



Alleged to have given undue favours and incentives to a liquor manufacturer by notifying its investments as a mega project, going against norms

SANJAY RATHOD
FDA Minister



Accused of illegally allotting 10 acres of gairan land worth ₹10 crore in Washim as MoS revenue during the 2014-19 BJP-Sena regime, despite the district collector ordering action against the allottees for submitting fake documents



SHAMBHURAJ DESAI
Excise Minister

Charged with illegaly constructing a house in an eco-sensitive zone at Navli village in Mahabaleshwar

UDDHAV ASKED IT POINT-BLANK: "THE SHINDE CAMP MUST THINK...HOW AND WHY ARE THESE CASES COMING OUT?"